

BOOKS



FROM ENCYCLOPEDIAS TO NOVELS, books are a vital record of human life and achievement. They store the thoughts, beliefs, and experiences of individuals and societies, preserving them after the author's death. There are many kinds of books, from religious works, such as the Qur'an, and non-fiction, such as dictionaries and educational books, to fiction such as plays and stories. The Chinese invented printing in the 9th century; it arrived in Europe during the 15th century. Printing made it possible to mass-produce books, and knowledge was spread more widely. Today, publishing is a global industry.



Early Chinese book, made of fragile bamboo strips

Early books

The first books were not made of paper. Long before 3000 BC, the Sumerians wrote on clay tablets. Around 1300 BC, the Chinese began making books from bamboo strips bound together with cord.

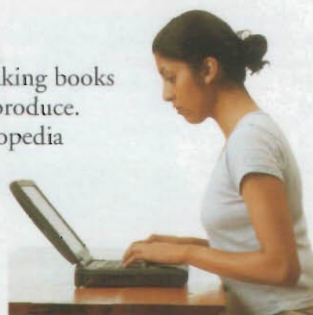


Making books

Much preparation goes into making books and some take several years to produce. For example, making an encyclopedia will involve a team of people that includes authors, editors, designers, picture researchers, illustrators, photographers, and IT experts, as well as printers.

Illustration

The designer draws a detailed plan, showing the position of each illustration. The artist makes rough sketches, which are checked, then paints each picture separately. The artwork is photographed, and carefully positioned on the page using a computer, until the design is perfect.



Author

The author is the first person to start work, researching and writing the contents of the book. The author advises the designer on suitable images for the book and works closely with the editorial team throughout the project.

Papyrus plants grow by the Nile.

Paper

The ancient Egyptians wrote on scrolls made from papyrus, which grew by the River Nile. Later civilizations in the Middle East wrote on parchment made from animal skin. Modern paper was probably invented in China around AD 150. It was made by pulping flax fibres, then flattening and drying them in the sun. The Chinese kept this process a secret for 500 years before they passed it on to the rest of the world.

CD Roms

There is a limit to how big any book can grow before it becomes too heavy and cumbersome to be practical. Now, modern technology is developing compact alternatives to traditional books. One CD Rom can contain as much text as a shelf of encyclopedias. Text and pictures from CD Roms can be read and transmitted by computer.



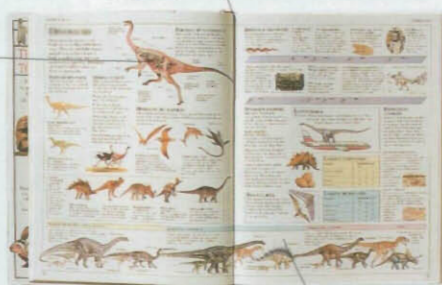
Text

The text is edited on a computer screen, and then produced as a page called a proof. The proof is matched with the artwork to make sure that words and images fit exactly, before going to the printer.

The printed colour matches the original artwork as closely as possible.

The editor checks the author's text for mistakes and adjusts length of text if necessary.

The spine of the book holds the pages in place.

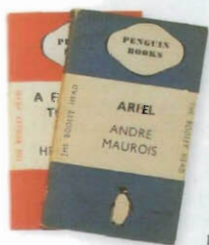


Pictures and text are perfectly integrated.

Finished book

At last the book is finished, and fitted with a hard cover and a protective jacket. It is now ready to sell. An illustrated book may take several years to make, although new technology is speeding up this process.

CD Rom



Paperbacks

A paperback book contains the same text as a hardback, but has a soft cover. The first modern paperback books were published in London by Penguin, in 1935, priced sixpence. They are far cheaper than hardbacks, and many more people can buy them.

Timeline

c. 285 BC Egyptian pharaoh Ptolemy I establishes a library at Alexandria, Egypt.

AD 300s Books with pages first invented.

Gutenberg Bible

c.1440 Johannes Gutenberg invents the metal type.



1789 French Revolutionaries proclaim the fundamental public right to print without fear of censorship.

1796 Lithography (a technique for printing illustrations) invented.

1811 First totally mechanized printing press invented, USA.

1935 First paperback books published for mass market by Penguin in UK.

1980s Electronic books for the computer published in CD Rom format.

1990s Books first published on the Internet.

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